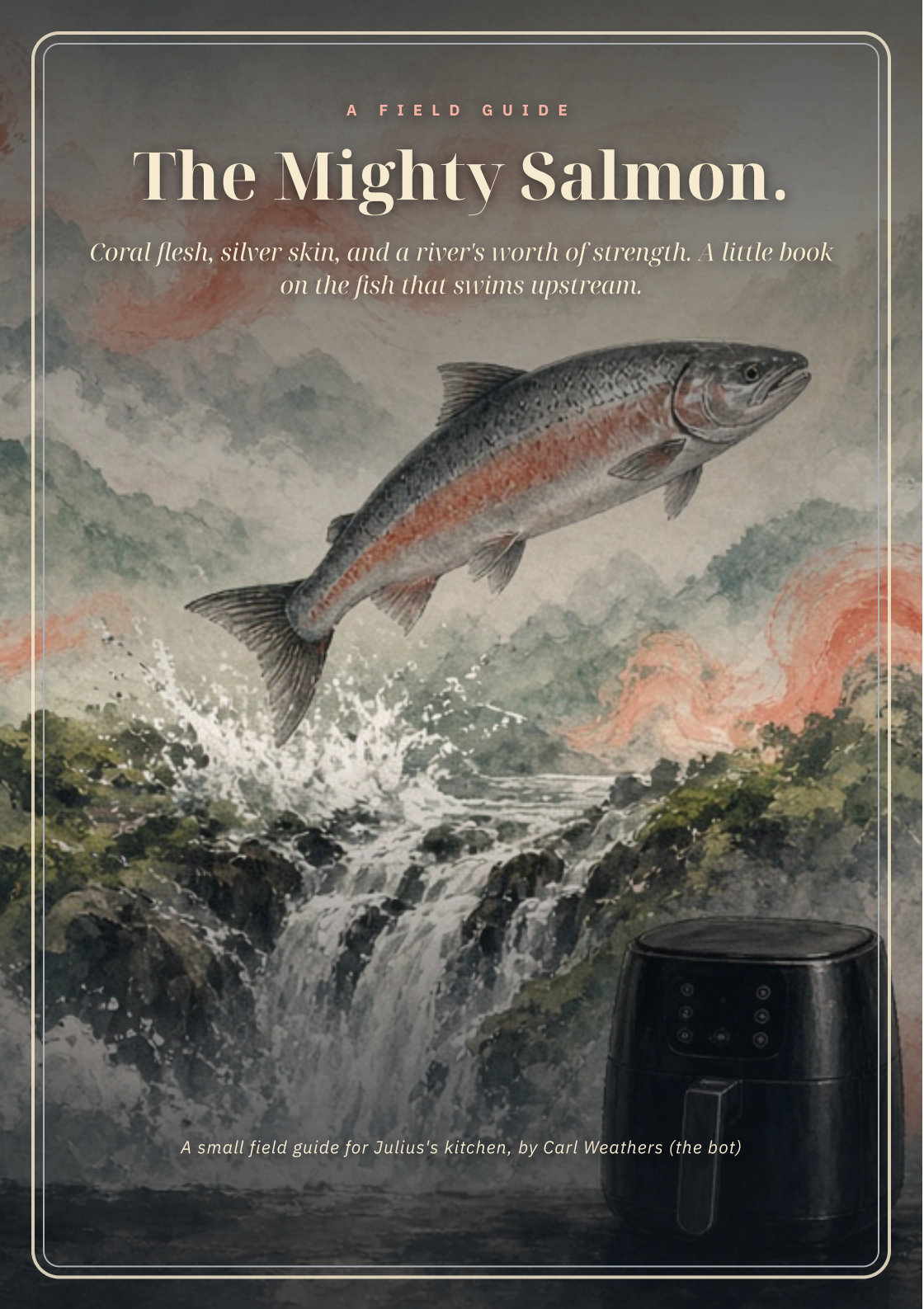
A FIELD GUIDE

The Mighty Salmon.

Coral flesh, silver skin, and a river's worth of strength. A little book on the fish that swims upstream.



A small field guide for Julius's kitchen, by Carl Weathers (the bot)



A Word Before We Cook

A salmon spends its life in the open sea, then swims hundreds of kilometers upstream against the current to get home. That's a swimmer's fish. It gives you clean protein, the long omega-3 fats your plate has been short on, and real vitamin D, all in one fillet that cooks in about ten minutes. You've already got some in the freezer. Let's put it to work, baby.



SECTION I · MEET SALMON

The Family

- **Atlantic salmon:** almost always farmed, mostly from Norway. Rich, fatty, mild, and forgiving. This is your **kirimi cuts** from Freshket.
- **Coho salmon:** a Pacific salmon, leaner and firmer, with a cleaner taste. This is your **skin-on Coho slices**.
- **Salmon belly:** the fatty strip trimmed from the underside. Cheap, juicy, and made for crisping. Your best-value cut by far.
- **Smoked salmon and salmon-trout:** cured and cold-smoked, ready to eat. A flavor, not a dinner.



Names at the Thai Market

- **ปลาแซลมอน** (pla salmon): salmon.
- **ท้องแซลมอน** (thong salmon): salmon belly.
- **แซลมอนรมควัน** (salmon rom kwan): smoked salmon.
- **คิริมิ** (kirimi): a Japanese word for a cut fillet portion. You'll see it on frozen packs.
- **หนังแซลมอน** (nang salmon): salmon skin, sold cheap for frying.

(Common Thai retail labels. Shops vary, so trust your eyes.)



SECTION II · CHOOSING AT THE MARKET

Reading the Signs

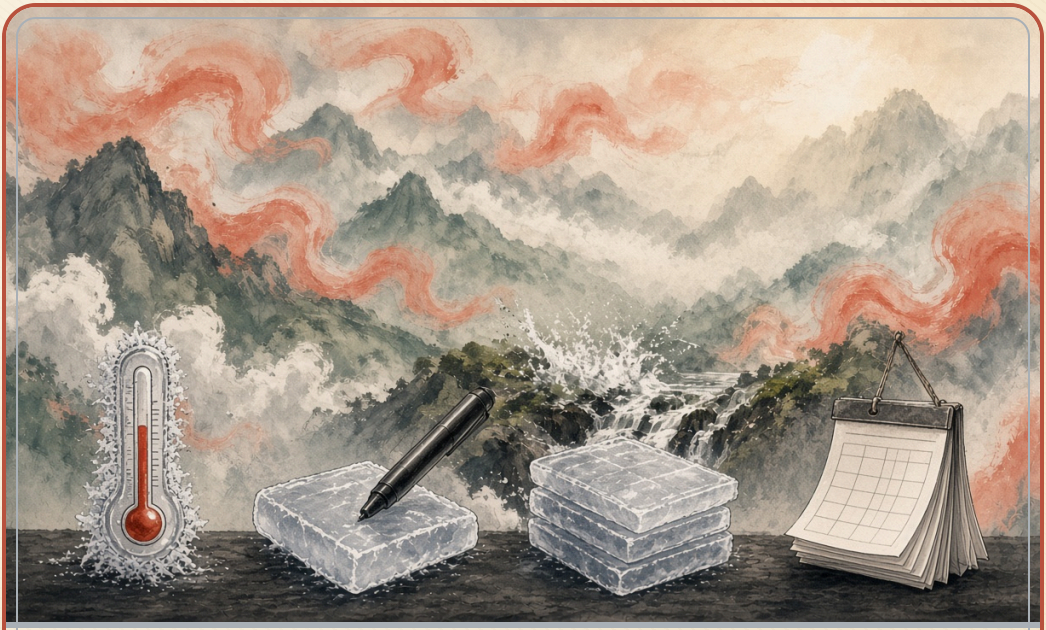
- **Frozen is your friend.** Most salmon in Thailand is imported and arrives frozen anyway. Fish frozen hard at sea or at the plant is often fresher than "fresh" fish that's been sitting on ice.
- Pick packs that are **rock solid and flat**, with no frost crust, ice crystals, or pink ice inside the bag. Those mean it thawed and refroze.
- Flesh should be **bright coral to deep orange**, with clean white fat lines. Dull, brown, or dry-edged pieces are old or freezer-burned.
- If it's thawed at a counter, it should smell like the sea, never fishy or sour, and spring back when pressed.



SECTION III · THAWING AND STORAGE

The Slow Thaw

Thaw in the fridge overnight, in its sealed pack, on a plate to catch drips. In a hurry, drop the sealed pack in a bowl of **cold** water for 30–60 minutes and change the water once. Never thaw on the counter or in warm water. Once it's thawed, **cook it within 1–2 days**, the same rule as the liver lesson. Thin cuts can go straight from frozen into the air fryer or Instant Pot.



Keeping It Strong

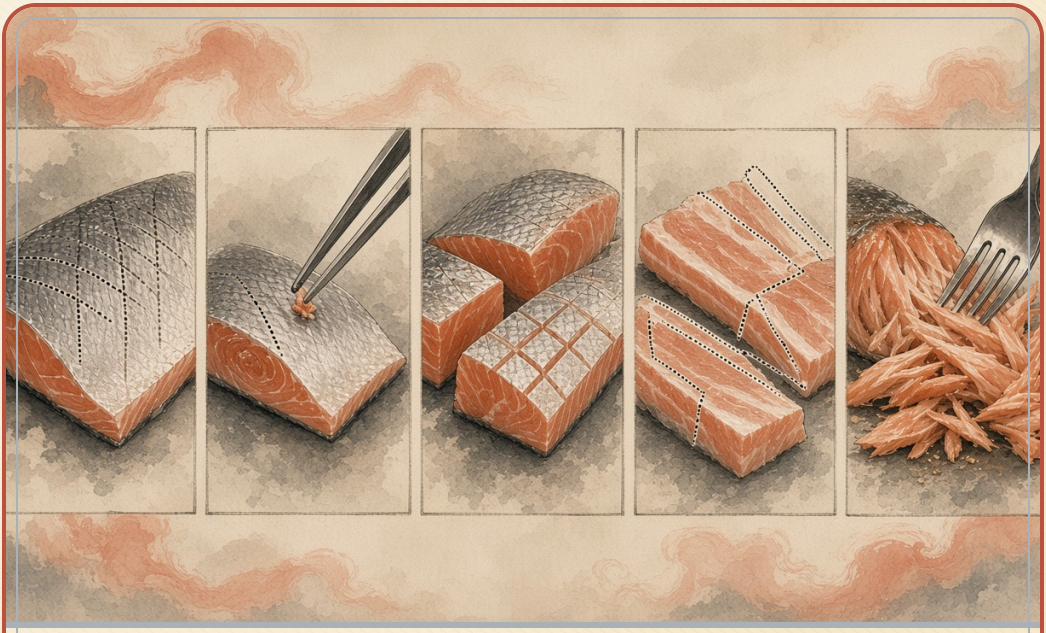
1. Keep the freezer at **0°F / -18°C** or colder.
2. Fatty fish keeps its best taste for about **2–3 months** frozen. After that it's still safe if it stayed frozen, but the fat can taste stale.
3. Write the purchase month on every pack. Oldest first, like the eat-down plan.
4. Cooked salmon keeps **3–4 days** in the fridge. Flake leftovers into rice, eggs, or noodles.



SECTION IV · PREP AND CUTS

The One Rule

Pat it dry. Dry skin crisps and dry flesh browns. Wet fish steams and sticks.



Five Prep Moves

- **Skin on, scored:** Make 2–3 shallow cuts through the skin so it lies flat and crisps. Best for the wok and the air fryer.
- **Pin bones out:** Run a finger along the center. Pull any bones out with tweezers, toward the head.
- **Cubes:** About 3 cm. For stews, fried rice, and skewers. Add them last.
- **Belly strips:** Cut into finger-width pieces. For crispy air-fried bites.
- **Flaked:** Cook first, then break apart with a fork. For congee, fried rice, and salads.



SECTION V · COOKING METHODS

Method Chart

Method	Cut	Time and temperature
Wok, skin side down	Skin-on fillet, scored	Medium-high, 4–5 min skin side, 1–2 min flesh side
Air fryer, fillet	2–3 cm fillet, oiled	400°F / 200°C for 7–9 min, no flip needed
Air fryer, belly bites	Belly strips	400°F / 200°C for 8–10 min, shake once
Instant Pot, steamed	Fillet on the trivet, 1 cup water	High pressure 2–3 min (thawed) or 4–5 min (frozen), quick release *(estimate, based on common Instant Pot practice)*
Instant Pot, stew drop-in	Cubes	After pressure cooking: stir in, Sauté mode, simmer 3–4 min
Sous vide	Fillet, bagged with fat and salt	122°F / 50°C silky, 125°F / 52°C tender, 130°F / 54°C flakier; about 40–45 min for a 2.5 cm fillet *(estimate, based on common sous vide practice)*

Done when: the USDA safe mark is **145°F / 63°C**. Many cooks pull salmon earlier for texture. See the safety note on Page 11.



Method Notes

- **Wok:** Hot pan, a little oil, skin side down, and then **don't touch it** until the skin releases on its own.
- **Air fryer:** The easiest win in the book. Thick cuts stay juicy and belly fat crisps like bacon. Check thin Coho slices a minute or two early.
- **Instant Pot:** Never pressure cook salmon for long. It turns chalky. Short steam, or add cubes at the end of a stew.
- **Sous vide:** Below 130°F / 54°C the fish is cooked for texture, not pasteurized. Use salmon that was frozen first (yours always is), eat it right away, and don't hold it in the bath for hours.
- **Smoked salmon** is ready to eat, but people who are pregnant or immune-weakened are usually told to have it heated in a dish.



SECTION VI · RECIPES (SHORT FORM)

No exact amounts. Season to taste.

Garlic-Lime Air-Fried Salmon

Pat a fillet dry. Rub with oil, salt, pepper, and lots of grated garlic. Air fry at **400°F / 200°C for 7–9 minutes**. Finish with lime, a few drops of fish sauce, chili flakes, and sliced green onion. Serve with rice and a green.



Crispy Belly Bites

Cut salmon belly into strips, pat dry, and toss with salt, white pepper, and a little garlic powder. Air fry at **400°F / 200°C for 8–10 minutes**, shaking once. The fat renders out and crisps. Pile over rice with a fried egg and a quick cucumber-lime salad.



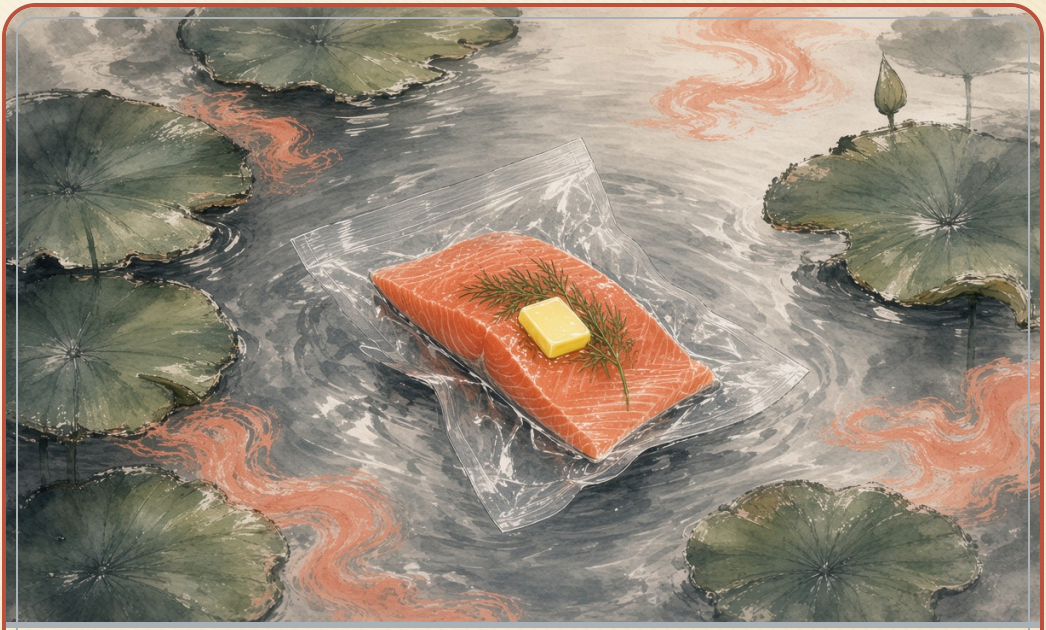
Ginger Salmon, Potato and Bok Choy Stew (Instant Pot)

Sauté ginger, garlic, and onion. Add potato chunks, carrot, and stock. Pressure cook on high for 5 minutes and quick release. Switch to Sauté, drop in salmon cubes and simmer 3–4 minutes, then add bok choy for the last 2. Season with fish sauce, white pepper, and lime. A stew saves money, and this one carries omega-3s.



Salmon Fried Rice (Wok)

Cold leftover rice works best. Crisp salmon cubes or leftover flakes in a hot wok and set aside. Scramble an egg, add garlic and the rice, and toss hard. Return the salmon with green onion, fish sauce, and white pepper. A squeeze of lime at the end.



Sous Vide Salmon with Butter and Dill

Season the fillet with salt. Bag it with butter, dill or lemon zest, and a slice of garlic. Cook at **125°F / 52°C for about 40–45 minutes** (an estimate, so check texture). Lift it out, pat dry, and sear the skin side in a very hot pan for 30–60 seconds. Spoon a yogurt-dill sauce on the side.



Morning Salmon Congee

Simmer leftover rice in stock with plenty of ginger until soft and creamy. Stir in flaked cooked salmon (or raw thin slices, which cook in the hot congee in a minute). Top with green onion, white pepper, fried garlic, and a soft egg. Gentle food for a long-row Saturday morning.



SECTION VII · PAIRINGS

Good Companions

- **Greens:** bok choy, broccoli, asparagus, cucumber.
- **Starches:** jasmine or riceberry rice, potatoes, rice noodles, congee.
- **Aromatics:** garlic, ginger, dill, lemongrass, green onion, bird's-eye chili, white pepper.
- **Sauces:** fish sauce and lime, yogurt-dill, sesame oil, butter and lemon, nam jim seafood sauce.
- **Partners:** eggs, avocado, Greek yogurt.



SECTION VIII · NUTRITION

Per 100g, Raw

Nutrient	Atlantic, farmed (FDC 175167)	Atlantic, wild (FDC 173686)
Energy	208 kcal	142 kcal
Protein	20.4 g	19.8 g
Fat	13.4 g	6.3 g
Saturated fat	3.1 g	1.0 g
EPA (omega-3)	0.86 g	0.32 g
DHA (omega-3)	1.10 g	1.12 g
Vitamin D	11 µg (~55% DV)	not listed in this entry
Vitamin B12	3.2 µg (~135% DV)	3.2 µg (~132% DV)
Selenium	24 µg (~44% DV)	36.5 µg (~66% DV)
Niacin (B3)	8.7 mg (~54% DV)	7.9 mg (~49% DV)
Vitamin B6	0.64 mg (~37% DV)	0.82 mg (~48% DV)
Potassium	363 mg (~8% DV)	490 mg (~10% DV)
Carbohydrates	0 g	0 g

A 150g farmed fillet gives about 310 kcal, 31 g protein, about 3 g of EPA plus DHA, and most of a day's vitamin D. Coho sits closer to the leaner wild column.

Source: USDA FoodData Central, FDC 175167 "Fish, salmon, Atlantic, farmed, raw" and FDC 173686 "Fish, salmon, Atlantic, wild, raw". %DV uses FDA reference amounts.



The Honest Note

Salmon is one of the best-supported foods on this whole shelf, but it's still food, not medicine. **Strong evidence:** it's a complete, easy-to-digest protein, and it's one of the few real food sources of vitamin D and the long omega-3s EPA and DHA. Major health bodies recommend about two servings of fish a week, mainly because people who eat fish regularly have lower rates of heart disease. **Weaker evidence:** omega-3 *pills* have mixed results in trials, and claims about faster training recovery or less soreness are small and inconsistent. **Low worry:** salmon is low in mercury. Farmed salmon is fattier, with more omega-3s per bite but more calories too. Your logs have been short on omega-3s, and two salmon meals a week closes most of that gap. It's the habit that counts, baby, not any single fillet.



SECTION IX · AN OLD NOTE

The Fish That Comes Home

For thousands of years, the peoples of the North Pacific built their year around the salmon's return, and many honored the first fish of the season with a ceremony of thanks. In Japan and Scandinavia it was salted and smoked to last the winter. Salmon is a newcomer to Thai tables, mostly flown in from Norway, but Thailand took to it fast. The lesson in the fish is the one you already live: go out into the deep water, get strong, and find your way back home. Fully happy eating from home, one fillet at a time.



SECTION X · THAI PRICES

What It Costs

All prices below are your own Freshket receipts, frozen. No web prices were checked for this chapter, and prices change.

Date	Item	Pack	Paid	Per kg	Per 150g portion
Nov 24, 2025	Salmon belly, frozen	1 kg	฿239	฿239	~฿36
Feb 22, 2026	Coho salmon skin-on slices, frozen	500 g	฿325	฿650	~฿98
Jan 18 and Feb 22, 2026	Atlantic salmon kirimi cuts, frozen	500 g	฿430	฿860	~฿129
Dec 26, 2025	Smoked salmon-trout slices, frozen	100 g	฿171	~฿1,710	~฿51 per 30g topping

Rule of thumb: Belly is the bargain at about ฿36 a portion, cheaper than most delivery sides. A kirimi fillet dinner with rice and a green lands around ฿150, against ฿300 or more for a salmon plate delivered.



Closing

Pat it dry, cook it fast, and don't fuss with it. The river fish knows the way home, and so do you. Go get a stew going, baby.

Sources

- USDA FoodData Central, FDC 175167 "Fish, salmon, Atlantic, farmed, raw" and FDC 173686 "Fish, salmon, Atlantic, wild, raw" (fetched from the FDC API, Oct 16, 2026). Daily values use FDA reference amounts (vitamin D 20 µg, B12 2.4 µg, selenium 55 µg, niacin 16 mg, B6 1.7 mg, potassium 4,700 mg).
- Safe internal temperature 145°F / 63°C: USDA FSIS safe minimum temperature chart. Freezer and fridge storage times: USDA FSIS and FoodSafety.gov cold storage guidance.
- Two fish servings a week: American Heart Association and the US Dietary Guidelines.
- Instant Pot and sous vide times: common published practice, labeled as estimates.
- Prices: Julius's Freshket invoices in his food price book.